sound quality and volume levels are better than on most other laptops.

The R61 is all about quality. It has that subtly sturdier build that comes from use of quality material both inside and outside. All ThinkPads come with hard drive protection inbuilt, and the R61's hard drive head will park if the sensor inside the notebook detects a sharp change in G force (as in a fall). Loads of nifty little features like a light near where most laptop webcams are ensures that your keypad stays illuminated even if the rest of your room is not. The R61 also features a brilliantly crisp resolution—1440 x 900—something all but extinct in this category.

ASUS' F3Jc has a beautiful keypad—well-laid out, and even better feedback. The feedback from the touchpad is also positive and accurate, in fact, it's on par with the excellent ThinkPad R61. A far cry from this is the HP DV6226tx; as with the Presario v3225AU, the touchpad offers insufficient feedback due to its slippery-smooth surface.

BEST BUY digit JULY 2007

HP DV6226tx
A great buy!

Incidentally, ASUS' F3Jc also has DVI connectivity—a welcome and rare feature. Equally rare was the fact that this laptop ships with two batteries—one compact for regular use, and the other a large 7200 mAh battery pack.

Performance

The Lenovo R61 features a jaw-dropping T7700, the absolute top-end laptop processor from Intel's Core 2 Duo line-up. Running at 2.4 GHz and featuring an 800 MHz FSB, this CPU happily ate up all the data it was being fed by the 2 GB of fast 667 MHz memory that the R61 has under its hood. Coupled with the Intel 965PM a.k.a. the Santa Rosa platform, the R61 is an über-number-cruncher.

ACI's Matrix 1501 is another hot performer, featuring the T7200 processor and 2 GB of memory. Additionally, this laptop features the ATI X1600 graphics processor with 256 MB of dedicated video memory—enough to send most casual games into orbit.

A shade behind these come the ACI Matrix 1425, HP DV6226tx, and ASUS F3Jc, featuring the NVIDIA 7400/7300 Go.

How We Tested

We slotted the laptops into four categories.
Value Laptops (up to Rs 45,000): The laptops here are mostly entry level solutions from most vendors. However, recent price reductions also mean this category holds exceptional value for money. Better hardware is trickling down to this segment.
Performance Laptops: This category comprises the laptops with good enough configurations for power users and those who demand more processing power and speedier performance.
Ultra-portables: These are for those who want something with a small footprint: something light, and therefore easy to carry around. This category is populated by models with screen sizes up to 12.1 inches.
Lifestyle Notebooks: These have nothing in common really, aside from the fact that they're different! Everyone would love to own one, they have oomph. They're drool-worthy.

Pre-test

We did a clean format on all the laptops, creating a primary partition of 30 GB and a secondary partition of what was left. We installed a fresh copy of Windows XP SP2 on those laptops that came bundled with Windows XP. The ones bundled with Windows Vista got a fresh copy of Windows Vista Ultimate Edition. We used all the latest drivers from the manufacturers' Web sites.

Features

We took special note of ergonomics—something that most people fail to realise is very significant. We rated the keypad layout, the feel of the keys while typing, and ergonomic enhancements like switches and buttons for enabling and disabling functions like Bluetooth, Wi-Fi, the touchpad, and more. We also rated the feel of the palm rest, another significant, oft-overlooked parameter.

Finally, we rated the laptops on their build quality, looking separately at parameters like body, keypad, and movable parts.

We felt it equally important to rate specifications like storage space, the presence of connectivity options, the number of USB and FireWire ports, and functional add-ons like card readers and webcams.

Performance

Our tests, as always, consisted of a gamut of synthetic benchmarks and real-world tests.

Synthetic Tests

PC Mark05 tests a computer's most pivotal components and provides a macro as well as micro look of those. The CPU, hard drive, memory, and graphics subsystems are benchmarked, and an individual as well as overall score is brought up.

3D Mark 2005 is a well known graphics subsystem test. It tests the pixel and vertex processing of a graphics solution and brings up an overall score.

We used DisplayMate to judge the quality of the screens. In particular, we concentrated on its suite of colour tests.

WirelessMon 2.0 was our benchmark of choice to test signal strength (as a percentile) in Zones 1 and 2. For those who remember, we used these Zones in our Wireless Router/Access Point test earlier this year. For those who don't, Zone 1 was a replication of a scenario where the laptop and the wireless access point were in the same room, though approximately 15 feet apart. Zone 2 saw the access point and the test subject 25 feet apart with a cement wall in between.

Real-World Tests

We used a 1080i clip to test the candidates on their ability to provide a good movie-watching experience. We watched for skipping of video and audio, as well as screen anomalies. We judged onscreen colour rendition.

Our video encoding test consisted of a 100 MB .VOB file being converted to DivX. This is a test of the laptops' CPUs more than anything else, but hard drive and memory performance do play a small part.

The file transfer test saw us copying a 1 GB file from the primary partition to the secondary partition of the laptops' hard drives. This tests the storage subsystem.

Our game benchmarks consisted of an OpenGL and a DirectX based game each, Far Cry and Doom 3 respectively. These games were benchmarked via a fixed "timedemo" (a *rendered* clip consisting of a fixed number of frames), with settings at medium, and the resolution at 800 x 600.

In the wireless bandwidth test, we transferred a 50 MB file wirelessly between a Desktop hooked up via RJ45 to the access point (802.11g ready) and the test subject. To arrive at the bandwidth figure, we divided the file size by the amount of time taken.